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Howie Shear

Trumpeter and composer Howie Shear attended SUNY Fredonia, the Eastman School of Music, and the University of Southern California, where he completed his Doctorate in Music in 2002. He played lead trumpet with the Woody Herman Band and has enjoyed a successful career in the L.A. Studios. Howie is active as a composer and arranger and served as the music director for the Joan Rivers late night talk show. He is the author of Jazz Improvisation Simplified.

Howie was interviewed in Dunkirk, NY on October 11, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm talking with trumpeter Howie Shear, just outside Fredonia, and we were at Fredonia but I think I got out just before you came in.

HS: Sounds like a prison.

MR: I don't know, did we think of it as a prison at the time?

HS: No. But you got out.

MR: We remember the good.

HS: Oh this is my favorite place in the world.

MR: Is that right?

HS: Absolutely.

MR: Well that's interesting. And I should also address you as Dr. Shear, right?

HS: Yeah.

MR: Have you finished your Ph.D.?

HS: Oh yeah. About 12, 14 years ago.

MR: Good. Well what did you — I'm trying to think how to phrase this question — right now, in 2014, are you doing, in the music business, what you aspired to when you were here?

HS: In 2014? No. No. I was some — when I first got out of school, when I moved to Los Angeles. There was a lot of work and what I really aspired to do was play in the studios as a trumpet player. And there was still quite a bit of work back then. And I always wanted to compose and orchestrate and I did a lot of that. There was a lot of work. So I wasn't really teaching a lot, although I did teach privately, I didn't teach in many of the schools yet. But as the technology got better and life went on, there was less and less and less, oh, real instruments playing in the studios. Instead of four trumpets on our date, there was maybe one, maybe two, but one and sometimes none.

MR: Well let me ask about that. Is that because the parts were being overdubbed with synthesizer trumpets or were they just two guys playing, record them twice or all that kind of stuff?

HS: Both that. I still get called to do four parts. But yeah, most of the time it's synthesized trumpets. You get TV themes. Not movies really, but a lot of TV themes that have trumpets on it and they're very synthesized. So there's no trumpets on those. And the movies you do hear that. There's really ten percent of the epic movies, the big movies like the remix of *Robin Hood* where they need a hundred piece orchestra, where you have trumpets. But that's about ten percent. The other 90 percent of the films in Los Angeles are done in the home studios. And I myself have done four scores to films. And one film they gave me a live orchestra. The other three films I had to record it in a midi studio. So I paid people out of my own pocket to come in and sort of like I had a live cellist so it made the other strings sound more real. Or I would put a trumpet over it and maybe synthesized sounds sound more real, and I've got a French horn player or maybe one oboe player. So I hire several musicians to make the synthesized sounds sound a little more real. But that's most of what's going on.

MR: Well I want to come back to that. But you said when you — what was it like when you first entered the business out there?

HS: As far as?

MR: The studio scene.

HS: Oh a lot of instruments. A lot of trumpets and woodwinds and trombones. They didn't skimp.

MR: And so you would get a phone call and what kind of information would they give you?

HS: Oh they'd say it's a jingle or a TV show or a movie, they'd specify, and they'd say it's you and three other trumpets and maybe four bones and 30 strings or ten strings or full up. They would tell me what kind of work it was and the equipment I needed — if I needed a flugelhorn, if I needed mutes, and things like that. I would just bring that anyway.

MR: And who is it that makes that call?

HS: Well back then you had a service. So you'd sign up and you'd pay a nominal fee. And a lady would call you up and say well I have a date for you at Paramount or whatever the studio was, Evergreen, or whichever studio. And they would say downbeat is 9 a.m. and it's a jingle for Burger King or some product or whatever or some beer commercial. And they'd say it's a 3-hour call or it's a 6-hour call.

MR: Did you mention someone's name? You said someone named Lynn or somebody? Oh I thought you said someone's name.

HS: No. A service.

MR: Okay a service. And is that the same person as the contractor?

HS: No. The contractor would give the A list —

MR: I see.

HS: Then if someone couldn't make it — because there was a lot of work and people's time would be, you know — they would cross them off and call the next guy in line. And so they had an A list and a B list.

MR: And is there a price difference for what the A list people make per hour?

HS: No, but if they really wanted, for some reason, a famous person on, not a jingle but maybe a live TV show, they would pay double or triple scale. Or if they really wanted an exceptional soloist to play a solo in back of a singer on her CD, well album at that time, they would pay double, triple scale. But mostly everybody just got single scale.

MR: So in those days if you were watching television or in your car on the radio and you heard a Burger King commercial you might say oh, that's me.

HS: Yeah. I've walked in malls to go shopping and I'm in the store and I heard myself on a Barry Manilow album once, and things like that. And I'm saying it sounds familiar — oh I just did that. You know it's kind of surreal.

MR: I'll bet it is.

HS: Yeah, and exciting at the same time because that's really everything I ever wanted to do is play in the studios see. I saw a big challenge in that.

MR: How much of that skill required can you attribute to Fredonia and/or Eastman?

HS: Oh everything. There's nothing I saw — let me see if I can phrase this correctly — there is no music I saw in the professional world that was as difficult as I saw in college. It's all easy after that. Because in college, you know, don't forget, if you're selling soap, they don't want you listening to the music so it can't be very difficult.

MR: That's a perfect way to put it. Yeah, sure.

HS: Yeah. But yet it's still challenging to you, to the player, to get it right the first time because you know, the contractor doesn't want to go like that and go —

MR: We have to take another take for that? Yeah.

HS: We do do several takes. It's not as instant as one may make it out. We do get to rehearse it, we do get to play it several times, and it's pretty polished by the time we do it. Because we get called, it's a 3-hour call, whether we're there three minutes or three hours. The pay is the same. After three hours then it goes up. So they figure to have us, let's get a half a dozen takes or more in the book.

MR: Was most of it wearing headphones and playing to something that was already recorded?

HS: Yeah. Most times the rhythm section was on track already so we were with phones, and played to the click-track it's called. I mean we had click, and we also had drums, so if the drummer wore a click-track he'd be right with it so it didn't matter which we listened to. Sometimes the click-track would be annoying because it's just a click-click — it would be a metronome. So we'd ask to shut the click off and we'd play to drums. Yeah. And that's most of it. Some of it was live. But they'd want to get it perfectly. So you know the

way that a TV show, like an award show, which I did a lot of award shows, and you'd see the guy going to commercial and that's a lot of pre-record, so we're not even playing. Sometimes we are, but a lot of times it was pre-recorded so it's perfect. They didn't want instruments making mistakes on air.

MR: Like give me an example. What kind of show would that have been?

HS: Well I did — oh just so many things — The American Film Institute awards, where they honor somebody every year for their work, like Jack Lemmon I did and people like that. And a lot of times they would go to commercial especially and you'd make believe you're playing, which is already recorded.

MR: You know it's funny you say that because I don't watch those shows a lot but sometimes I'd watch them, and they would announce a winner or something and boom, immediately — and I'm thinking how do the guys shuffle their music so fast?

HS: Well we know in advance who's going to get an award.

MR: Okay.

HS: Well the conductor does, and he'll call a tune out. And you can figure it out from the music that you're going to play. So sometimes it is actually — and we do play. But other times it's sort of pantomiming to what we already recorded. It's us on tape. Yeah. Same thing in movies when you see musicians in a scene and they're playing. They're not really playing. I've done a lot of that.

MR: You've done a lot of that?

HS: Oh yeah. It's called sidelining.

MR: Oh it's called sidelining?

HS: Yeah. Yeah. Oh movies like *The Mae West Story* and *PeeWee's Big Top Adventure* or whatever that was, and a lot of movies like that we see live bands. *Brewster's Millions* with Richard Pryor, going back to the 80s. They did a lot more of that then. But most of the time we'd get there very early and pre-record ourself. And then we'd just play to our own tracks. Because they don't want that sound while people are giving dialogue.

MR: Right. They want to have some control.

HS: Absolutely. They want all the control. Which is fine with us you know. It's work.

MR: Yeah. And you get extra work for being on film, extra bread for being on film.

HS: Yeah, yeah.

MR: Do you have to join another union?

HS: No, no. As long as you belong to the American Federation [of Musicians]. Yeah.

MR: Okay. How is the union — I don't want to get too sidetracked here, because this stuff is fascinating to me — but —

HS: There's a lot to it.

MR: The union — how is it handling this business about the synthesizers and the studios —

HS: Poorly.

MR: Poorly.

HS: They don't represent the musicians at all. It's a musicians' union but they keep on making deals — they keep on making deals with people who they need to make deals with, and the musicians are the last to get what's ever fair. So they don't handle it well. The pits in the orchestras and for shows are being — constantly being cut. The fees — the money isn't going down but the quantity of musicians are fewer. And so instead of back in the 80s when I was doing some shows in the theater district in Los Angeles, we had 15 strings, now we've got two keyboards and maybe four strings. And then we have two woodwind players playing 15 woodwind instruments. And it's one or two trumpets instead of four. A lot has happened. And it didn't start in the 80s, it started in the 60s, you know, as the years went on the number of musicians would dwindle. And the union really doesn't stand up for you very much.

MR: Don't you wish that the audience would stand up and say, "I want an orchestra"?

HS: Yeah. But they don't know.

MR: They don't.

HS: It sounds big, they turn up the bass and they turn up the keyboard, and it sounds big. And the audience is fulfilled.

MR: It is stunning. Because we have Broadway Theater tickets, or we did, in Utica. And I had second row seats and I could always look down, "oh my God there's like six people down there." And the technology —

HS: It's very truncated.

MR: It's just so perfect that you almost say to yourself well you might as well just have nobody. I don't mean that but —

HS: Well it's going there because the synthesizers can duplicate strings beautifully. So they don't need strings. They might need a couple of horns here and there, trumpet, trombone, French horn, woodwinds. Because the synthesizers aren't really perfectly duplicating the breath that you need to play an instrument like that. So it would sound a little squirrely. But strings sound beautiful on synthesizers and there's hardly anybody down there anymore.

MR: Yeah. I can't remember the last time I saw string players in those pits. Does it irk you to have to do that when you were doing those scores? To do what you had described earlier? You'd have a cello player come in —

HS: Oh film scores, well —

MR: It's just reality?

HS: Absolutely, yeah. The first movie I did, you know I'm not in the big movie thing yet because it's very difficult to get in, but the movies I have done are good movies. They're

known as B movies. And the very first one they got me actually 40 strings and about 12 other people: woodwinds, French horns, percussion, that type of thing. So they did pay. The producers paid. And then I did midi stuff. And I was just fortunate enough, you know, I know the greatest musicians in Los Angeles because I've lived there so long, so I could call up a really good oboe player — and yes, you feel good that you could do that but then you feel bad that you can't hire four trumpets and give people work. My favorite thing to do is to give people work. I love giving people work. You know I love contracting a gig and I can say okay I need you on this and you on that and you on this. It just fills me.

MR: Yeah.

HS: Because I know what it is to get called for work.

MR: Yes. You used to be on the other end of that.

HS: Absolutely. So I wish I could do that more. But you know going in, when you're scoring the film that you are going to have maybe half a dozen live players to sweeten it up. Now most film scorers or composers, they don't even do that, they just go completely with synthesizers.

MR: Are you a keyboard player also?

HS: I could get around. I don't play classical music like Mozart, because I wasn't trained like that, but I can certainly — I play what's called arranger's piano.

MR: I love that term.

HS: Yeah. So I can get around.

MR: Because I was wondering, well how do you write — how did you write for the film if you're not a real pianist.

HS: I don't think it's necessary. I could write for — the last film I did I took a DVD player to a coffee shop and I watched the film and I scored it in a coffee shop. I hear it in my head. I gather the melodic material at home and I just write the melodies I want in certain parts of the film and then I just score it in my head. I know how it's going to sound.

MR: Using Finale or Sibelius or one of those things?

HS: No. I go home and after — still my favorite process is score paper and a pencil. Because that's how I learned. And then I transfer it into Sebelius. Because I'm very proficient in Sebelius now, the music program. So I score it in my head in a coffee shop, or I could do it right to Sebelius if I want but I like the 3-D. I like to get my hands filled with pencil smell you know.

MR: I know. I just returned to that a couple of weeks ago and I said this feels good. The notes seem to mean more.

HS: It's three dimensional. You know? And then I'd go home and transfer it. So I don't really use any sort of tools to orchestrate. I kind of look at the scene and I try to put forth the emotions that they want from that scene and I can hear it in my head, and then I score it.

MR: And at what point do you run it by whoever can say yes or no? Before you get too far into it?

HS: At no point could they really hear it. Because I tell them they can hear it if they want to, but they usually just leave it up to me for the session. Because if they hear it on my computer it's going to sound like a bunch of noise to them. They're not going to really hear how the real instruments are going to sound. They're just going to hear a cheap imitation of how it's going to sound. And it's a lot of trust involved. There is major composers that have scored major films that had their scores thrown out by the producers before the movie was released obviously, but after the recording session. They just didn't like it. And they would hire another composer to sit and —

MR: Oh —

HS: Yeah. So they have money though. These producers have money you know.

MR: Yeah. They're probably insured for that.

HS: Probably so. There you go.

MR: Who are your favorite film scorer people?

HS: Oh gosh, well Max Steiner from the early days of film was one of the greats. I think Bernard Herrmann, who did *Psycho*, the movie *Psycho*. And he really changed the way, especially strings are scored in films. And Bernard Herrmann, he did a lot of the "Twilight Zones" early on. And then he did many of the Hitchcock films. I think he died in 1974 I believe. I think *Taxi Driver* was his last film. But he also did the original *Cape Fear* back in the 40s and the score was so great to that that when they redid it with DeNiro they kept the score, they just reworked it.

MR: I didn't know that.

HS: Yeah, they said it can't be better than that. We can't get anybody to — so I think Bernard Herrmann is my favorite; and Jerry Goldsmith, who passed away a few years ago, who studied with Bernard Herrmann, he's one of my favorite scorers. So those three come to mind right away. And then there's Korngold of course, from the older school.

MR: Korn—

HS: Korngold yeah. He's a European composer also. He was known as a swashbuckling composer because he did all those pirate movies, like the original *Robin Hood*.

MR: Are you a guy who gets random checks in the mail for things that you did in the past?

HS: Yeah, yeah. Jingles that they might re-use. TV shows you don't get residuals. Most of the stuff you do not receive residuals, not quarterly or anything, you get a yearly check and they total up what you did on records every August I think and they send you a check. It

could be a penny, it could be $40,000. It depends on how many records you're on. And then they do the same thing for films. They're called special payments. And the guys who have been in Los Angeles a while who really are into that, that fell into that, were very lucky fortunately. They could get checks for 50, 60, 70 thousand dollars every year. And then other guys could get checks for $200 every year. So yeah, special payments funds. And I did a lot of game show jingles at one point. That you get paid every — the musicians get checks for every six months I believe. So we get some residual things but it's mostly the yearly special payments checks.

MR: Would you know if you were getting or not getting something that you should? How the heck do you keep track of that?

HS: No, I remember once I did a big telethon, one of the telethons, back in the 80s, and for some reason they re-ran this thing three days after it ended. And it was never done before like that. And one of the 80 musicians who were in the orchestra saw it and called up the union. And the union didn't even know. So they got on it and we got paid 100 percent again. But you really wouldn't know. There are supposedly librarians who keep track of all that, who work for the union or the TV show, and every time a station, like NBC or ABC or whatever station, releases music for something that people have recorded that the librarian fills out a cue sheet and sends that to ASCAP or BMI. Now there it goes through channels and whenever that happens, you never know, and then BMI or ASCAP takes care of cutting the musicians a check. But things could go over their heads, you know, the librarians, and they might not submit something. So there are instances where it happens. I don't think it happens often. I think they're pretty good at that.

MR: And it goes without saying that those studio years, you just have to take care of business. You have to be on time, you can't have attitude, I mean the whole thing.

HS: The whole thing. Yeah. You have to be on time which means you've got to be fairly early. Now if you want to warm up properly if you didn't get a chance to at home. And then you could look at the music ahead of time, and meet the guys. My favorite thing to do is still playing, even though I like to orchestrate. Because orchestrating and composing is a very lonely life. You sit at home, or if you have an office and there's no one, it's eerily quiet and I don't like that. I like a little chatter. But when you're a musician showing up, "hey, Joe, how's it going?" Yeah you meet the guys, you tell a few jokes, you know it's kind of like what you've done growing up, sitting and playing in bands. And there's a lot more camaraderie going on because, like I said, the other part of it — composing — is very lonely. But it's very satisfying also. So I like both parts. But my favorite thing is just showing up playing and sort of going home. There's a lot less responsibility. When you are a composer there's a lot more responsibility going on. And

I'm a responsible person, so that part doesn't bother me. But you have to plan. You have to plan.

MR: Did you, in the heyday, did you see some student musicians trying to, you know, make two dates at basically the same time — play the system?

HS: Oh yeah. Absolutely. Yeah. And I myself did that in case one gets canceled or then one gets pushed back two, three, four hours, and you could always cover yourself because there's always somebody good that could substitute for you for something. You call the contractor up and say I'm so-and-so, I'm sorry I can't — something happened I can't make this particular session but I have a great sub coming in. You try not to do that, because you don't want the contractor getting upset 'cause he wanted you. So the big guys could do that. You know when I talk the big guys — when I first got to town the big guys, you know —

MR: Who were the big guys?

HS: On trumpet?

MR: Yeah.

HS: Chuck Findley, Jerry Hey, Gary Grant. They did a lot of the Michael Jackson stuff and the Quincy Jones stuff with Michael Jackson. That was a big section. And Malcolm McNab is the movie guy in L.A. There's a lot of players that had been in the scene way before I got there. And if for some reason they couldn't make something because something came up, they would still get called again. But if I as a young guy that walked into town and got called for something and I couldn't make it, and I called up the contractor and told him that, he might be a little bothered and he would either say well I'll get somebody, and you may not hear from them again. It's a tough call, to overbook yourself.

MR: I've had guys tell me that they had to be wary about going on the road, even if it was a good deal, because by the time they got back —

HS: Out of sight, out of mind. So I would never tell people I was out for a week or a month or six months. When I was out of town for long periods of time, which I don't do anymore, there were no cell phones. So now you don't ever have to tell anybody you left town, you just get the call, and you could be in Ames, Iowa and say yeah, I'm around the corner, but I can't meet you now because I have a — you know you fly home. When I was doing the *Joan Rivers Show*, I was the musical arranger for the Joan Rivers late night show, and I would get called to do, oh two, three, four week things in Lake Tahoe or Reno, for the show I was affiliated with, and I wouldn't tell the *Joan Rivers Show*. I flew up — I did the show in Tahoe or Reno and I'd sometimes, every day during the day. Fly in, hand in music, and then get a sub for my Reno or Tahoe show for three or four days, because I played in the band too. And I was doing double duty. And I didn't have a phone really.

But I would make sure that neither would know I was out of town. So you're doing a lot of juggling.

MR: You didn't learn that at Fredonia. Or maybe you did.

HS: Which party to go to. So you learn how to do that. As long as you're covering yourself, and the show in Reno and Tahoe was not a big deal and there's plenty of musicians in those towns that needed the work. But I would never turn down the *Joan Rivers Show* to stay in Reno but I would always get a sub for Reno for three or four days and come back to L.A. And I was flying back and forth for a long time. It was kind of fun because I was in my early 30s and I had a lot of energy. And it was kind of nice living that lifestyle never knowing where I'd be on a given day or night.

MR: What was she like to work for?

HS: She was wonderful. She was wonderful. Unfortunately it only lasted a year. It should have still been on, at this point it would have been on over 30 years.

MR: Big group too, huh?

HS: Yeah. It was like an 18-piece big band. And I got to write — oh I wrote 98% of the material. Nothing prerecorded. Played everything live, and it was live to everywhere in the country except in L.A. where they prerecorded it. So I got to play on the show, then I went home and watched it, to see if I could have improved something or other.

MR: That's cool.

HS: It was kind of a fun gig. But she was a great, great, great person to work for.

MR: And you took an early detour from the studios to go with Woody Herman?

HS: Yeah, that happened early on when I moved to Los Angeles, so I didn't really — although I did do some studio work right away in L.A. I turned it down when they first called me. I'll never forget it. It was in the evening and I had to play a gig. So during the gig I was saying I should take that Woody Herman thing. Not that I needed to move out of town but I think it's a big deal because they called me to play first trumpet, lead trumpet, and the lineage of lead trumpet players that Woody's had through the years is just extraordinary, and to be a part of that list. And back then it was sort of a rite of passage. If you had that on your resume people would sort of — oh wow — I've had this come up in the studios and it was a big deal. If I got a call to play second or the third with Woody I probably wouldn't have done it. Not to be an elitist or anything — and believe me I'm not — but it's a very important chair to play. So I took it and I did it for a couple of years.

MR: Boy, when I was here, that kind of thing, the jazz guys, that was a goal. There wasn't that many big bands left but boy we just, oh God, if we could go with Buddy Rich.

HS: Absolutely.

MR: You know, Stan Kenton came here and we just like thought that's what we want to do.

HS: Exactly. Yeah, and the big big band I always wanted to play with was Woody. Thad Jones too, which I ended up playing with in New York when I got out of Eastman — I lived with my folks in New York for one more year to study trumpet, and then I moved to L.A. and that year I was on — well it was mostly Mel's band, at that point Mel Lewis' band. Thad was already in Sweden or somewhere living. So that was the other great band I wanted to play with.

MR: Do you happen to know why he just picked up and left?

HS: Thad? I guess he had it from New York all those years. Maybe he wanted to live an easier life. And In Europe they have all these radio orchestras so you could get your music played every day and there's a lot of opportunity. They love jazz there, much more than I think the United States, although Thad did live in New York, which is the thriving city for jazz I think in this country, still.

MR: I assume when you were with Woody Herman maybe the road travel had improved some? Or was it still —

HS: Well they treated us a little better on Woody Herman's band than the other bands like Glenn Miller, Tommy Dorsey, which were known as ghost bands because the leader had died. But they had to sleep on the bus a lot, where Woody's band never, we never had to sleep on the bus. There would always be a hotel. You wouldn't make a lot of money at all. I hardly saved any money in those two years. So you know going in that you're not going to make a lot of money, you'd better do it for the love of it and opportunities that might arise later on. And three months before I got off the band I played the retirement party for Beverly Sills, the opera singer, on the side of Lincoln Center they put up this giant tent with chefs and everything. And there was a guy that was listening to the band, because not too many people were listening, they were eating and chatting. And one guy and his wife were listening to the band and he came up to me and talked to me and we talked and he said when I got back to Los Angeles to give him a call. Turns out he was a very big composer of some big shows, and I fell into the scene right away because of that. Yeah, I just got lucky. So it's networking. It's one thing I didn't get a lot of information from is networking, when I was in school. It was all about playing. It wasn't about how to conduct yourself, although at that point you should know how to conduct yourself. But you have to know where to hang out and meet the right people and say the right things and have the right equipment, and all that stuff was not taught. You had to really — I learned that late and I should have learned it earlier.

MR: Can you teach it?

HS: Absolutely. When I give clinics I always speak about that. It's very important. It's as important as playing well.

MR: So what do you tell a student not to do?

HS: Don't be unprepared. Be prepared. Now I have several bags/satchels in my car at home in Los Angeles. And I have everything I've ever written on CDs. I've written everything from children's books with music, to hard bop jazz quartet albums, to film scoring, jingles, and things like that. And if I run into somebody, which you always do in Los Angeles, especially in the town I live in. I have stuff to give them right away. Because if you say oh are you going to be around tomorrow — you'll never see them again. And if you're not prepared with stuff — and it's so easy to be prepared now, you just burn CDs on your home laptop. You don't have to go into these places and pay big money. It's practically free. So I'm always burning CDs, I see what I'm lacking and oh I need more of those or more of those. And I'm constantly preparing. Yeah. You want that? You want that? You want that? Here it is. And that way they know that they don't have to go shopping for it and calling 50 people up, "you got something like this, I mean, for a scene in a movie?" It's right away. And so you have to be prepared. Yeah. You have to have date books. I know you have electronic phones now and cell phones and pads and all this stuff, but you still need, I think, cards, business cards, or something. Because a lot of times people will lose information on electric devices, you know IPads or the cloud will eat it up or something, and who knows. So I still have paper stuff I give people. I have a date book, I write in a date book. I don't use my phone for those things. I use my phone for a phone.

MR: It's probably our generation I suppose, they don't want to let go of that.

HS: You know I've got a lot of students that are in college. I teach at several universities and I teach privately. And they're constantly forgetting things. I still don't forget anything. And yet they have all the devices and they know how to use them as well as anybody, and they are still forgetting things. And they set alarms and reminders and I don't understand that but, you know, so, it might be a generation thing but they're still forgetting a lot more than I forget. And I write it down with a pencil in my date book. But you've just got to be prepared with everything that you need for the business of music. And I also have a motto, "don't turn anything down." If someone comes up to me, which has happened, a parent and says my child is playing cello, could you teach cello. Well I can't teach cello but I say yes, sure. And what I do is I find her or the parent a cello teacher for their child. I'm brokering the deal. As long as the cello teacher shows up that's all you need. And that way you could start another business, which I have, by contracting. So I give the cello teacher $50 and I'll make $25 — not of the $50, I'll charge $75 for the lesson, and I could make some money with the legwork that I do contracting musicians. So I not only can give musicians work but I also make a little money and that's how music offices have started. If someone wants a band for their wedding, yeah I could do that. I've done that thousands of times. I know the best players

in town and have a band for their wedding. Whatever you need to do so you can stay in the game and you don't have to get a day job it's called. And I've never had to do anything else.

MR: I just was going to ask that.

HS: No I never had to do anything else after I moved to Los Angeles.

MR: Why did you go there instead of New York?

HS: Well one is the lifestyle. I didn't want to have to share bathrooms with people in an apartment that's four by eight. Yeah, and you really have to live in Manhattan. You can't really live in Queens or Brooklyn. I know some people live in Brooklyn and New Jersey, but if you get a call and you need to be there in a half-hour you want to live in Manhattan. You want a cab to take you right there. And I didn't really want to do that. And I wanted to score films and TV as well as play, and that's really where the capital is in this country anyway.

MR: I've had a couple of Hamilton students who have graduated and are working on becoming a film scorer. And I wonder how do you learn to do that?

HS: Watch a lot of films. Really. And you sort of take notes. I write everything down. If I — and you can rent them too, you don't have to wait for it to come on television. Or now you could just download it or NetFlix. Say you want to listen to suspense music. Well spend a few weeks or months just watching suspense films from the beginning of film up and see maybe how it's evolved or stayed the same, and then as far as how they set movies, what instruments and what instruments are doubled with other instruments, and the sonorities of sounds that these great composers got to scare you, or to make you feel that feeling of suspense. And it's all from that. It's hard to, you know I teach classes in orchestration at this school in Los Angeles, and it's tough to get it from a book. That stuff you can't get really from a book. You can learn ranges and how the instruments sound, because they have a lot of recordings of, you know, you could buy a Mozart French horn concerto and CD and listen to the French horn. You know how it sounds. But as far as understanding how to get certain sounds out of instruments coupled with other instruments to give you the sense of fear or suspense or happiness or whatever, you just have to watch films. And whatever emotions are making you feel the way you do, it's probably going to translate that with everybody that's watching that film. And make notes. Like have a book of suspense cues and what you've heard from it. And then when you have the opportunity to write some music, try it out. You could always hire musicians to read through music, because musicians always want to get together and play, and then go down to the union and just buy them lunch — buy a pizza and they'll read through the music and then you could record that and see how it sounds, and there are many ways. But it's a very difficult thing to teach. When I teach orchestration I don't

say cello and clarinet is a wonderful combination for so-and-so. You have to — that's just my point of view. And I could cite movies where that happens, but they might not like that sound. So they have to figure out for themselves what they need to do to get that sense of feeling for whatever mood they want to be put in from the movie. So you learn from all the old composers, a lot of them from the composers that I named. And that's what I did when I was in school and when I got out of school. I would sit down and watch a movie and I would listen — oh I like that — you know, that's a clarinet and a flute in half steps and then there's a French horn with the ascending line to create tension. And I would write that down. And I might try that if that ever happens. You learn from the greats.

MR: I recently watched "Twelve Years a Slave" and boy there was some really interesting music in that.

HS: Yeah, I haven't seen that yet.

MR: Some of it I couldn't even tell what is making that sound. Very, very interesting.

HS: Yeah. Well a lot of — well that could be synthesized sounds now. They have so many of them. Third world sounds and you can buy all that stuff that are sampled by real players that sound real. That's good news and bad news. It's great news for composers, but it's bad news for the musicians. And there's plenty of times where I had to play music in a studio that — for singers — and knowing that the singers will not hire musicians anymore because they have a prerecorded tape for their act.

MR: How ironic.

HS: Exactly.

MR: I'm replacing myself.

HS: I'm replacing myself exactly. Yeah. And that's a big part of it because you're making a paycheck for that day but you know if you didn't do it somebody else would do it. Not that that's the right thing to do or the wrong thing to do, it's just a judgment call at the time. And there's a lot of things I've turned down in Los Angeles in my career because I felt it wasn't the correct thing to do.

MR: Like?

HS: Stuck by my ethics.

MR: Can you think of an example?

HS: Well yeah. I used to get called to play horn parts in the studio for particular singers — not famous singers, just singers. And it was very low pay but it was early in the 80s so I could still pay my rent from the things I was doing. And then several years went by and it would stay the same, and several more years went by and it stayed the same, and then I asked for more money and never heard from that person again. And you've got to expect that. You've got to expect that, because there's not a lot of solidarity among musicians.

There are musicians I know that say well I'll just play for lunch, you know, just bring us some lunch in the studio and I'll do it. For various reasons that I know, a lot of musicians, they don't do it as their primary income. They have day jobs. They might make enough. Like I know somebody who's a paralegal who plays an instrument, and he doesn't really care what he makes as a musician because he makes enough as a paralegal. And this is, yeah, it's a big problem.

MR: If you had a 3-hour jazz brunch gig in Los Angeles, what's the average musician get paid for something like that these days?

HS: Well let me think back to the 70s. Same thing. You get hardly anything. Yeah, it might pay $30 a musician, or $40. Now back in the 70s that was about a quarter or a third of your rent. Now if your rent's $1000 instead of $150, now that gig should pay a third of your rent, which is $300 or something, but it still pays 30, 40 dollars. Most jazz gigs, it doesn't matter if it's a brunch or a jazz club. Some jazz clubs you still get the door.

MR: Yeah. I think I was out there probably 15 years ago, at the Baked Potato or something.

HS: The Baked Potato. I live a couple of miles down. You still get the door.

MR: They what? They get the door?

HS: They get the door. And it's not even the whole door, it's 80% of the door. So it's not enough that they don't pay you, they still want a cut of the door. And so I used to play there, but no, I can't call musicians anymore, the kind that I want, and say it's the door or it's $30 or it's $40. I just can't make that call.

MR: Well I'm interested in — there's a description here about how you define some of jazz teaching as like higher math. Higher mathematics. And that really rang a bell with me because I have felt the same thing and I'm wondering if you can sort of sum up your thoughts.

HS: Was I criticizing that?

MR: No. Well you were — about the book and method you put out.

HS: Oh yeah.

MR: And it was an attempt to simplify.

HS: Simplify jazz, yeah. *Jazz Improvisation Simplified*. Yeah when I was first learning how to play I would go to certain people in the area where I was going to school, before I started school, before I started my master's in jazz studies. And they couldn't seem to explain it to me. That's a lot of the old-timers — at that time they were old-timers. They sort of learned how to play with records. They didn't have books or academics on how to play jazz. And they didn't explain it very well. So I said I'd better figure it out. And then I looked at some books in the stores (when they had music stores) and the books were very difficult to understand and I felt like I was going to school to learn quantum physics, in which case I go oh let me figure this out myself. So I sort of figured it out myself. And

then over the years I said I should write a book for my students particularly, and anybody else that wanted it obviously, but to explain all the books that were at a very high level. There were no books that led up to that. And so it's like learning calculus without learning the essence of arithmetic and the foundations of arithmetic. So I wrote this book and I tried to simplify everything that you would get. But yet it's not a dumbed-down version, but it's what players need to know to improvise quite well actually. So it's not simplified for just like the novice or the grade school kid. It's really like Charlie Parker played jazz and after him. But a lot of people who wrote these books are very — at a high level and they just like to flex their bebop muscles, and they like to speak in a very high academic language to make them appear smarter than they really are, although a lot of them are very smart people, don't get me wrong. But they didn't really think about the person that didn't really know how to play. They thought about the person that already knew how to play. And I wanted to think about the person that didn't really know how to get started. And I get a lot of emails today thanking me for writing that particular book. And I'm glad about that. Because I think it's important. Because we want to continue the art form.

MR: Do you think it's harder for a young player today to find an original sound because they have so much codified material to draw from.

HS: Well you have to realize that the codified material is half of it, and the other half is sort of the primal part of you, the creative part of you that wants to take that vocabulary or that lexicon and then play it in a very non-academic way. So if you could be Jekyll and Hyde in the sense that two different people, in order to get across what you want to get across. But yeah, there's a lot of players out there that forget about that other half, they're very academic about it and they say well the book says to play this particular scale over this particular chord so they do that. And they sound correct. But I think in any art it's not enough to sound correct or look or be correct. It's when we start coloring outside the lines, that's when I think a person's creativity is really explored. And unless you do that you will always play correctly but you won't necessarily be as creative as you should be, I think, in art. So I think one should color within the lines first, which is what my book's about, and then you'd have all that knowledge and material and then take that material and start coloring outside the lines. So I think personally that's the avenue I took and I'm glad I did.

MR: So are there wrong notes in improvising?

HS: Well — no, no, no. It's basically you have a choice of all 12 notes of the chromatic scale. It's a good thing we don't live in the Middle East where they have 48 notes and 96 notes. I mean we think we have it difficult in Europe and the Americas, and now in the Middle East where they have micro-tunings in India, it's got to be extremely difficult and their

minds are just rife with information. We've got 12 notes, and they can all be used. But where are they used and how are they used is, at this point — at that point when you understand how to play through chord changes, the harmonies, then it's all about not what notes all the time, but how to use the notes and where to put those notes. So in answer to your question I think that's sort of what I did. I could play perfectly and play just the notes I need to play, but then the other chromatic tones are very important too, like they are in J.S. Bach's music. It's the same vocabulary. We have names for notes that didn't really fit in the chords as appoggiaturas and —

MR: Oh, right.

HS: and escape tones, which are known as echappées, and upper neighbors and lower neighbors, and grupettos and all that. In jazz it's the same thing. You know Charlie Parker didn't call it that, but it's exactly the same thing.

MR: Yeah. We call it after he played it.

HS: Exactly. Yeah. And those are the colors of jazz, those notes. You know it's like taking a black and white painting, which is sometimes beautiful, and then once in a while throw in some red, some blue, throw on some green. And those are those notes that we might not be allowed to play but we could make sense out of those notes so it's how we play them and where we play them that really give your composition — which it is a composition — color. A jazz solo is a composition, a spontaneous composition but nevertheless a composition, and sometimes we need more color.

MR: Well put. I'm guessing you get this question on occasion, either from a student or maybe from their parents, like gee, do you think I should go into jazz as a career.

HS: I do get that question a lot. But I always say yet but you should be able to teach, you should be able to play, you should be able to compose, you should be able to orchestrate, you should be able to do almost anything you can in music in order to survive and so you won't have to do anything else. If you just want to be a jazz player and nothing else it's very difficult. Very, very difficult. There's a couple of cities only to choose from. And there's Europe of course, and there's Asia, particularly Japan, and they love jazz in these places and you could probably make a better living in Europe than the United States. But if you're going to just be a jazz player, which I have a lot of friends that do want to do that, and they live day to day, month to month, year to year. Most parents don't want that for their child. Some parents say well whatever makes them happy is fine with me. So it depends on what you want out of life. If you want a family and a nice house and what the American dream used to be or maybe still is, and you just want to play jazz for a living I would say that that's extremely, extremely difficult.

MR: If you look at some of the — it's hard to think of a player, a guy like Joe Lovano, they all do other things that come along.

HS: Oh absolutely. Yeah, yeah, yeah. I think the greatest thing I ever did was learn how to play jazz. Two Augusts ago I was in Paris for two weeks. And when they hear you play, wherever it might be — this particular place was Paris — you just make friends immediately because it's a language. And you might not speak French — but I happen to speak French so I got along great speaking French — but if I didn't it wouldn't matter because I speak jazz and all these jazz people who come out speak jazz, or they want to speak jazz and they love jazz. So you make friends right away, which means you always have a place to stay and you always have a place to eat, and people say — and this was the case when I was on Woody Herman's band, we were in South America and I didn't speak a word of Spanish in any dialect, and yet — and there was not a lot of English going on there. But these group of trumpet players, 10, 12, 15 of them, took me out to dinner every night and treated me so well. And I felt like I was at home. So it's a language that I learned how to speak and it's basically an international language. Everybody knows it, speaks it, wants to learn it, and it's probably the single greatest thing I've ever learned. Plus most of my students are — they want to learn how to play jazz. I have some classical students and some students in orchestration, private students, but most, by-and-large most of my students, private students, want to learn how to play jazz, whether they are in eighth grade, or I have students in their sixties now and fifties who always wanted to do that, who are now kind of retiring so they could lose their job and then want to play jazz and it's all about that. And if I didn't learn how to play jazz that would have been a big part of my income that I wouldn't have been able to do. So it's the best thing I ever did was learn it. And I tapped into my own creativity. I think everybody's creative and I think everybody needs to explore where they're creative. If they just spend a little time seeking it out and asking themselves the right questions. Because as a classical player growing up, I didn't think I was very creative. I thought okay I was a good trumpet player and I could play that and I could play that, and I might teach music. And then I said well let me see if I could do this thing. And then as I learned more and more and I spoke the language of jazz better and better, I said well I guess I have some creativity there.

MR: It was kind of neat being at Fredonia in the 70s with the jazz band, because we sort of used to complain that there was no faculty and they weren't teaching it. But I think we also thought it was kind of neat that we had that passion and we ran this thing ourselves you know, and it was a real love affair with the music.

HS: Absolutely, yeah. Yeah I agree. I didn't quite play — I played in the jazz ensemble at Fredonia, and I played some solos but I was an ear player and I didn't really know how to play chord changes. I had good ears, and I had good feel, and I understood the sound of the language, but I was kind of not really speaking the language of bebop or hard bop or

— until I got into Eastman and I had the time to pursue it as a major. I was still a classical player here. But yes I agree, having something student-run, it's like owning your own dog instead of renting one. You really want to take care of it.

MR: So do all your contacts — do they know in Los Angeles that you're in Fredonia right now?

HS: No. No. And I teach classes at this one school, music theory, orchestration — I told one of my classes, my orchestration classes, that I'm going to be out of town for a week. But I didn't tell my music theory class. But I did send a sub to teach it. So they don't have to know. But my orchestration class, they're a group of composers. It's a required class. And they need to know how a composer lives his life. My music theory students don't really need to know that now. If they were in my composition classes I would. And I say okay this is what I'm doing, you want to do this for a living, I don't need to be here, this wasn't a required thing for me, but yet I wanted to bring a new chart along that I wrote, and see people that I used to know from a long time ago to see what they're doing. And it's networking for me too. In the mid 80s through the late 90s I used to come back here to Fredonia once a year for two, three weeks, and one time I came back for eight weeks as an artist in residence. And it was a great time for me because I got to come to a place I really love to visit. So my composition students know. Because again, I felt like it was very necessary for them to know the things you might have to do as a composer or an orchestrator. So they know.

MR: Well I've enjoyed this conversation a lot.

HS: Yeah, me too.

MR: What's in the near future for you? Anything —

HS: Well I go back, I teach, like I said, at several schools. And no studio things coming up but they just pop up at the last minute anyway. Because it's not like it used to be where they said I'm going to fill these chairs two weeks in advance. Because now there are so many people that are out of work, musicians that they could call — if I can't make it they'll make another call and they'll make another call and they'll make another call.

MR: God, where are all these graduates, these jazz graduates going?

HS: I know yeah. There's not enough music being written for live musicians anymore. So what are they going to do as players or teachers? There are many musicians, since my doctorate I haven't been interviewed for one teaching job even though I have several universities, they just know me as a player and a writer out there so they think of me for that. And they know I have a doctorate. But I didn't get these jobs I have because I have a doctorate. Because there are no full time jobs around now. Teachers who are teaching a lot of them wouldn't even be teaching. They're just musicians who never thought they'd be teaching but they happen to fall into it and they won't leave because there's not

enough playing work so — exactly. So there's not a lot of work for teachers, players, composers and orchestrators. It's a very difficult life right now. I sort of made a name in town for myself early on when there was a lot of work. And then once they hear you play well you're sort of in. But now these newer guys can't even get heard because there's no work. And if there is work they call the players like myself who have been in town for 25, 30 years. It's very difficult but that's the age old question right now, where are these students — and I talk to my students about that too. I said figure out what it is, you know, create your own niche. You have to create your own niche because there might not be one opened up for a long time. So if there's something that you do well that might not exist at this point, pursue that. It might open up the rest of your life for you to be able to earn a living.

MR: Well on that note we'll wrap it up. It's a good note.

HS: Yeah. It's a good note.

MR: Thanks for your time today.

HS: Sure. Glad to do it.